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Siblings Without Rivalry

*How to help your
children live together
so you can live too*

ADELE FABER & ELAINE MAZLISH

AUTHORS OF HOW TO TALK SO KIDS WILL LISTEN
& LISTEN SO KIDS WILL TALK

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Siblings *Without* Rivalry

*How to Help Your Children
Live Together So You Can Live Too*

Adele Faber & Elaine Mazlish



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*To all the grown-up siblings who still
have a hurt child inside them.*

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Behold how good and how pleasant it is
for brothers and sisters to dwell together in unity.

THE BOOK OF PSALMS

We'd Like to Thank . . .

Our husbands, for their ongoing support and encouragement of this project. They were a daily source of strength to us, especially when the going was slow.

Each of our offspring, who as young children provided us with the raw material for this book and who, as young adults, gave us valuable suggestions about what we might have done differently.

The parents in our groups for their willingness to explore with us and try out this “new approach” with their children. Their experiences and insights enrich these pages.

Everyone who shared with us their past and present feelings about their brothers and sisters.

Kimberly Ann Coe, our artist, who somehow was able to sense exactly what we were after in our cartoon illustrations, and create a lovable cast of parents and children.

Linda Healey, for being a writer's dream editor, strong in her support of her authors' message and style, gentle and persistent in her pursuit of excellence.

Robert Markel, for his unwavering support throughout our career and for his taste and judgment on which we've come to rely.

And finally, our mentor, the late Dr. Haim Ginott, who gave us our first vision of how the flames of sibling rivalry could be reduced to a small, safe flicker.

How This Book Came to Be

As we were writing *How To Talk So Kids Will Listen & Listen So Kids Will Talk*, we ran into trouble. The chapter on sibling rivalry was getting out of hand. We were only halfway through, and it was already over a hundred pages long. Desperately we went to work to shorten, tighten, eliminate—anything to get it into proportion with the rest of the book. But the more we cut, the more unhappy we became.

Gradually the truth dawned on us. To do justice to sibling rivalry, we'd have to give it a book of its own. Once that decision was made, the rest fell into place. We would put into *How To Talk* . . . enough material on handling conflicts to ease parents over the roughest spots. But in our “sibling book” we would have room to stretch out, to tell about our early frustrations with our own battling kids; to describe the eye-opening principles we learned from the late child psychologist, Dr. Haim Ginott, in the years that we were part of his parent group; to share the insights we gained from our families, our reading, and our endless discussions with each other; and to describe the experiences of the parents who took part in the workshops we subsequently created and conducted on sibling rivalry.

It also occurred to us that we had an unusual opportunity through our nationwide speaking engagements to find out what parents around the country felt about sibling problems. We soon discovered we had a hot topic on our hands. Wherever we went, the very mention of the words “sibling rivalry” triggered an immediate and intense reaction.

“The fighting drives me up the wall.”

“I don't know what'll happen first. Either they'll kill each other or I'll kill them.”

“I get along fine with each child individually, but when the two of them are together, I can't stand either one of them.”

Evidently the problem was widespread and deeply felt. The more we talked to parents about what went on between their children, the more we were reminded of the dynamics that produced such high levels of stress in their homes. Take two kids in competition for their parents' love and attention. Add to that the envy that one child feels for the accomplishments of the other; the resentment that each child feels for the privileges of the other; the personal frustrations that they don't dare let out on anyone else *but* a brother

or sister, and it's not hard to understand why in families across the land, the sibling relationship contains enough emotional dynamite to set off rounds of daily explosions.

We wondered, "Was there anything to be said on behalf of sibling rivalry? It certainly wasn't good for parents. Was there something about it that might be good for children?"

Everything we read made a case for the uses of some conflict between brothers and sisters: From their struggles to establish dominance over each other, siblings become tougher and more resilient. From their endless rough-housing with each other, they develop speed and agility. From their verbal sparring they learn the difference between being clever and being hurtful. From the normal irritations of living together, they learn how to assert themselves, defend themselves, compromise. And sometimes, from their envy of each other's special abilities, they become inspired to work harder, persist and achieve.

That's the best of sibling rivalry. The worst of it, as parents were quick to tell us, could seriously demoralize one or both of the children and even cause permanent damage. Since our book was going to be concerned with preventing and repairing any kind of damage, we felt that it was important to look once again at the causes of the constant competition among siblings.

Where does it all begin? The experts in the field seem to agree that at the root of sibling jealousy is each child's deep desire for the *exclusive* love of his parents. Why this craving to be the one and only? Because from Mother and Father, that wondrous source, flow all things the child needs to survive and thrive: food, shelter, warmth, caresses, a sense of identity, a sense of worth, of specialness. It is the sunlight of parental love and encouragement that enables a child to grow in competence and slowly gain mastery over his environment.

Why wouldn't the presence of other siblings cast a shadow upon his life? They threaten everything that is essential to his well-being. The mere existence of an additional child or children in the family could signify LESS. Less time alone with parents. Less attention for hurts and disappointments. Less approval for accomplishments. And most frightening of all, the thought: "If Mom and Dad are showing all that love and concern and enthusiasm for my brother and sister, maybe they're worth more than me. And if they are worth more, that must mean that I'm worth less. And if I am worth less, then I'm in serious trouble."

No wonder children struggle so fiercely to be *first* or *best*. No wonder they mobilize all their energy to have *more* or *most*. Or better still, ALL. Security lies in having all of Mommy, all of Daddy, all the toys, all the food, all the space.

What an incredibly difficult task parents confront! They have to find the ways to reassure each child that he or she is safe, special, beloved; they need to help the young antagonists discover the rewards of sharing and cooperation; and somehow they have to lay the groundwork so that the embattled siblings might one day see each other as a source of pleasure and support.

How were parents coping with this heavy responsibility? In order to find out, we devised a brief questionnaire.

Is there anything you do with your children that seems to help their relationship?

Is there anything you do that seems to make it worse?

Do you remember what your parents did that increased the hostility between you and your siblings?

Did they ever do anything that decreased the hostility?

We also asked about how they got along with their siblings when they were young, how they get along now, and what areas they'd like to see covered in a book on sibling rivalry.

At the same time we interviewed people personally. We recorded hundreds of hours of conversations with men, women, and children of diverse backgrounds ranging in age from three to eighty-eight.

Finally we gathered together all our materials, old and new, and ran several groups of eight sessions each on sibling rivalry alone. Some of the parents in these groups were enthusiastic right from the start; some were skeptical ("Yeah, but you don't know *my* kids!"); and some were at their wits' end, ready to try anything. All of them participated actively—taking notes, asking questions, role-playing in class and bringing back to each other the results of their experiments in their home "laboratories."

From all these sessions and from all the work we had done in the years before comes this book, the affirmation of our belief that we, as parents, *can* make a difference.

We can either intensify the competition or reduce it. We can drive hostile feelings underground or allow them to be vented safely. We can accelerate the fighting or make cooperation possible.

Our attitude and words have power. When the Battle of the Siblings begins, we need no longer feel frustrated, crazed, or helpless. Armed with new skills and new

understanding, we can lead the rivals toward peace.

Authors' Note

In order to simplify the telling of our story, we combined the two of us into a single person, our six children into two boys, and the many groups which we ran together and separately, into one. So much for rearranging reality. Everything else in this book—the thoughts, the feelings, the experiences—is exactly as it happened.

Adele Faber

Elaine Mazlish

ONE

Brothers and Sisters— Past and Present

I secretly believed that sibling rivalry was something that happened to other people's children.

Somewhere in my brain lay the smug thought that I could outsmart the green-eyed monster by never doing any of the obvious things that all the other parents did to make their kids jealous of each other. I'd never compare, never take sides, never play favorites. If both boys knew they were loved equally, there might be a little squabble now and then, but what would they really have to fight about?

Whatever it was they found it.

From the time they opened their eyes in the morning till the time they closed them at night, they seemed committed to a single purpose—making each other miserable.

It baffled me. I had no way to account for the intensity, savagery, and never-endingness of the fighting between them.

Was there something wrong with them?

Was there something wrong with me?

Not until I shared my fears with other members of Dr. Ginott's parent-guidance group did I begin to relax. It was pure happiness to discover that my misery had lots of company. Mine was not the only day punctuated by namecalling, tattling, punches, pinches, shrieks and bitter tears. I wasn't the only one walking around with a heavy heart, jangled nerves, and feelings of inadequacy.

You would think, having been young siblings ourselves once, that we would all have known what to expect. Yet most of the parents in the group were as unprepared as I for the antagonism between their children. Even now, years later, as I sit here leading my first workshop on sibling rivalry, I realize how little has changed. People can't wait to express their dismay at the disparity between their rosy expectations and rude reality.

“I had another child because I wanted Christie to have a sister, someone to play with, a friend for life. Well now she has her sister and she hates her. All she wants to do is ‘send her back.’”

“I always thought my boys would be loyal to each other. Even though they fought at home, I was sure they’d stick together on the outside. I nearly died when I found out that my older son was part of a group at the bus stop that was ganging up on his little brother.”

“As a man who grew up with brothers, I knew boys fought, but somehow I pictured girls getting along. Not my three. And the worst part is, they have memories like elephants. They never forget what ‘she did to me’ last week, last month, last year. And they never forgive.”

“I’m an only child so I thought I was doing Dara a big favor when I had Gregory. I was naive enough to believe that they’d automatically get along. And they did—until he started to walk and talk. I kept telling myself, ‘It’ll get better as they get older.’ If anything, it’s gotten worse. Gregory is six now and Dara is nine. Everything that Gregory has, Dara wants. Everything Dara has, Gregory wants. They can’t get within two feet of each other without kicking or hitting. And they both keep asking me, ‘Why did you have to have him?’ ‘Why did you have to have her?’ ‘Why couldn’t I be an only child?’”

“I was going to avoid sibling rivalry altogether by spacing the children properly. My sister-in-law told me to have them close together, that they’d be like puppies playing with each other. So I did and they fought all the time. Then I read a book that said the perfect spacing was three years apart. I tried that too, and the big one lined up with the middle one against the little one. I waited four years for the next one, and now they *all* come crying to me. The younger ones complain that the oldest is ‘mean and bossy,’ and the oldest one complains that the little ones never listen to him. There’s no winning.”

“I never understood why people worried so much about sibling rivalry, because I had no problem when my son and daughter were young. Well, they’re teenagers now and making up for lost time. They can’t be together for a minute without sparks flying.”

As I listened to their collective distress, I found myself wondering, “What are they so surprised about? Had they forgotten their own childhood? Why couldn’t they draw upon the memories they had of their relationships with their brothers or sisters? And how about me? Why weren’t my experiences with my siblings more helpful to me when I was raising

my own children? Maybe it was because I was the baby in the family, with a much older sister and brother. I had never seen two boys grow up together.”

When I shared my thoughts with the group, people were quick to agree that their children, too, were very different in number, spacing, sex and personality from the siblings with whom they had grown up. They also pointed out that our perspective was different. As one father wryly observed, “It’s one thing to be the child doing the fighting. It’s another being the parent who has to cope with the fighting.”

Yet even as we were coolly commenting upon the distinctions between our past and present families, old and powerful memories began to surface. Everyone had a story to tell, and little by little, the room became filled with the brothers and sisters of yesterday and the strong emotions that marked those relationships:

“I remember how angry I used to get when my oldest brother made fun of me. My parents would tell me over and over again, ‘If you don’t respond, then he won’t bother you,’ but I always did respond. He’d tease me incessantly to make me cry. He’d say, ‘Take your toothbrush and leave. Nobody loves you anyhow.’ That always worked. I always cried on that one.”

“My brother used to tease me, too. Once when I was about eight, I got so mad at him for trying to trip me while I was riding my bike that I said to myself, ‘This is enough. This has got to stop.’ Then I went into the house and called the operator. (I’m from a small town upstate, and we didn’t even have dial phones back then.) I said, ‘I’d like the police, please.’ The operator said, ‘Well, ummm . . .’ and then my mother came in and told me to put the phone down. She never yelled at me, but she said, ‘I’m going to have to speak to your father about this.’

“That night when he came home from work I pretended to be asleep, but he woke me up. All he said was, ‘You can’t handle your anger like that.’ My first reaction was relief that I wasn’t going to be punished. But afterwards, I remember lying there, feeling angry all over again. And helpless.”

“My brother wasn’t allowed to be mean to me, no matter what I did to him. I was ‘Daddy’s little girl.’ I could get away with anything. And I did some pretty horrible things. Once I threw hot bacon grease on him. Another time I punctured his arm with a fork. Sometimes he’d try to stop me by holding me down, but when he let go, that’s when I’d really hurt him. One day when my parents weren’t home, he punched me in the face. I still have the scar under my eye. That was it. I never laid a hand on him after that.”

“In my family fighting just wasn’t permitted. Period. My brother and I weren’t even allowed to get mad at each other. A lot of the time we really didn’t like each other, but no, you couldn’t get mad. Why? No reason. Just not allowed. It was, ‘He’s your brother. You *have* to love him.’ I would say, ‘But Ma, he’s a pain in the neck and he’s selfish!’

“‘Well too bad. You have to like him.’

“So a lot of my angry feelings got squished down, because I was afraid of what would happen if they ever came out.”

As more people shared their sibling memories, I marveled at how each recounting seemed to catapult the teller back in time and summon up the old hurt and anger all over again. Yet how different were these scenarios from the ones the parents had described earlier between their own children? The setting and the characters weren’t alike, but the feelings seemed very much the same.

“Maybe the generations aren’t that different,” someone commented ruefully. “Maybe we just have to learn to accept the fact that siblings are natural adversaries.”

“Not necessarily,” one father objected. “My brother and I had a very close relationship right from the beginning. When I was little my mother used to put him in charge of me, and he was always good-natured about it—even when she insisted that he see to it that I finish my bottle before he could go off to play. I didn’t want to have to finish my bottle, and he didn’t feel like waiting around, so he’d drink my bottle for me. Then we’d go out together and visit his friends.”

Everyone laughed. A woman said, “That reminds me of my sister and me. We were always in cahoots, especially when we were teenagers. We used to band together whenever we wanted to punish my mother. If she scolded or reprimanded us, we’d go on a hunger strike—one at a time. This drove my mother crazy, because she used to worry about how thin we were. She was always making us drink egg nogs and milk shakes, so when we stopped eating that was the worst punishment for her. But unbeknownst to her, we really were eating. The one who wasn’t on the hunger strike would bring food to the one who was.”

She paused and frowned. “But my younger sister is another story altogether. I never liked her. She was born ten years after me, and the sun rose and set with ‘the baby.’ To me she was just a spoiled brat. And still is.”

“That’s probably what my older sisters would say about me,” another woman said. “They were eight and twelve when I was born, and I think they were jealous because I was

my father's favorite. Also I had a lot of advantages that they didn't. There was more money when I was born, and I was the only one who got to go to college. My sisters were both married at 19.

"Now since my father's death, my mother and I have become very close. She's also become close to my children. Recently we were talking about turning her house into a mother-daughter house, and you wouldn't believe what's going on. When my mother told my sisters about our plans, they hit the roof. '*We* had to get a mortgage when we bought a house . . . *We* had to struggle to get what we got all these years . . . *She* went to college . . . *Her husband* went to college . . . *He* has a good job.'

"I think what bothers me most, is that now my nieces and nephews are resentful of my children. They say, 'Grandma, how come you spend all your time with them? You never come to see us anymore!' The jealousy never seems to end. It's gone down from one generation to the next."

Sighs were heard throughout the room. Someone commented that we were dealing with "heavy stuff" here. I felt the need to sum up before we moved on: "We've been looking at our own childhood and our children's childhood, and what we seem to be saying so far is that our relationships with our siblings can have a powerful impact upon our early lives, producing intense feelings, positive or negative; that these same feelings can persist into our adult relationships with our brothers and sisters; and finally, that these feelings can even be passed on to the next generation."

There was more, but I didn't quite know what it was. Again I thought of my own brother and sister, and how they treated me like a "pesty" kid who was always in their way, and how even now, as a reasonably successful adult, I still sometimes see myself as being "in the way." Aloud I asked, "I'm wondering, would it be going too far to say that these early experiences with siblings could determine how we act or think or feel about ourselves today?"

There was barely a moment's hesitation. Four hands shot up at once. I nodded to one of the fathers.

"Absolutely!" he said. "I'm a person who has to be in charge. And I'm sure it's because I was the oldest of my three brothers. I was the benevolent dictator over the younger boys. They always looked up to me and would do anything I told them. Sometimes I beat them up, but I also protected them from the bullies in the neighborhood.

“Even today, I have to be ‘on top.’ Recently I had an excellent offer to sell my business. The deal was for me to manage it for the new owners. But I know myself. I’ll never do it. I’ve got to be the boss.”

“I’m the youngest of five boys, and there’s not a doubt in my mind that my brothers affect the way I think about myself today. They’re all high-powered people, super-achievers—academically, athletically, you name it. Only to them it came naturally. When I was a kid, I was constantly trying to keep up with them. While they were having fun, I was upstairs grinding away at the books. They could never figure me out. They used to call me ‘the adopted one’—affectionately of course.

“To this day I push myself. My wife accuses me of being a ‘workaholic.’ What she doesn’t understand is that part of me is still running like hell to keep up with my brothers.”

“I stopped trying to keep up with my older sister a long time ago,” a woman said. “She was so beautiful and talented, there was never any contest. And she knew it.

“I remember once when I was around thirteen, we were dressing up to go to a family wedding. I thought I looked really nice. She stood next to me in the mirror and said, ‘I’m the GGG girl—Gorgeous, Glamorous, and Glorious.’ Then she looked at me and said, ‘You’re the SSS girl—‘Sweet, Simple, and Sincere.’ I’ve never forgotten it. To this day if anyone praises me, I think, ‘Yeah, yeah, but you should meet my sister.’”

“I was affected by my sister, too,” a woman said softly. Several people leaned forward to hear her. “She’s always been . . . an embarrassment to me.” She hesitated, took a breath, and went on. “From as far back as I can remember she’s had emotional problems and was always doing weird things that I had to explain away to my friends. My parents were always so concerned about her that I felt I had to be the good one, the one they could depend upon. Even though I was the younger, I always felt like the older.

“The only change over the years is that my sister has gotten worse. And everytime I see her—even though I know it’s not her fault—I feel resentful, as if she cheated me out of a normal childhood.”

I listened in amazement. I had always been aware of the part that parents played in shaping their children’s lives, but never until this moment had I considered how powerfully siblings could affect each other’s destiny.

Yet here was one grown man saying he still has to be the boss; another who is still driving himself to keep up, a woman who still feels she can never measure up; and

another who is still suffering from having to be “the good girl.” And mainly because of who their siblings happened to be.

As I was busy trying to digest my new thoughts, I suddenly became aware that a man in the group had been speaking for a while. I forced myself to concentrate on what he was saying.

“. . . so in my home it was my father who was the unstable one. My mother was very affectionate, very calm. But my father was a man of temper, a man of uncontrollable actions. He’d leave, saying he was going away for two days, and then he’d stay away for two months. So we all more or less huddled together to protect each other. The big ones looked after the little ones and we all took jobs after school as soon as we were old enough to work. Everybody pitched in with their earnings. If we all hadn’t stuck together nobody would have made it.”

A murmur ran through the room. “Mmmm . . . wonderful . . . beautiful.” This last story had touched the group’s deepest longings—to have children who would “be there” for each other with love, support, and loyalty.

One woman said, “That was inspiring! What you just described is everything I could ever hope for. But it’s also discouraging. I’ve heard of other families where the kids pull together because the parents have serious problems. I’d hate to think that my husband would have to walk out on me in order for my kids to start being decent to each other.”

“As I see it,” a man commented, “the whole thing is a genetic crapshoot. If you’re lucky, you get a winning combination of kids whose personalities go well together. If not, you’re in trouble. But either way, folks, it’s out of our hands.”

“I don’t accept that it’s ‘out of our hands,’” another woman retorted. “We heard a lot of examples here today of parents who made things worse between their kids, who actually drove them apart. I joined this group because I’d like my children to be friends someday.”

Where had I heard those words before? Aloud I said, “You remind me of me ten years ago. Only I was crazed on the subject. I was going to see to it personally that my two boys became friends. As a result I found myself on an emotional roller coaster. Everytime they played together nicely, I was elated. I’d think ‘There! They *do* like each other. I’m a wonderful mother.’ And everytime they fought, I would despair. ‘They hate each other, and it’s my fault!’ One of the happiest days of my life was the day I gave up the ‘good friends’ dream and replaced it with a more realistic goal.”

The woman seemed confused. “I’m not sure I know what you’re getting at,” she said.

“Instead of worrying about the boys becoming friends,” I explained, “I began to think about how to equip them with the attitudes and skills they’d need for all their caring relationships. There was so much for them to know. I didn’t want them hung up all their lives on who was right and who was wrong. I wanted them to be able to move past that kind of thinking and learn how to really listen to each other, how to respect the differences between them, how to find the ways to resolve those differences. Even if their personalities were such that they never could be friends, at least they would have the power to make a friend and be a friend.”

The woman seemed taken aback. I could see why. It had taken me a long time to make peace with what I had just summed up for her so swiftly.

“Please understand,” I said, “there were plenty of times when I was too tired, too disgusted, or too angry at the kids to even make an effort. But when I was able to help them go from a shouting match to a rational discussion, I felt terrific—like a very competent parent.”

“I don’t know if I could do that,” she said nervously.

“There’s no mystery about what I did. Whatever skills I used, you can too,” I reassured her. “And you will, beginning next week.”

She broke into a weak smile. “I might not last till then,” she said. “What do I do in the meantime?”

I spoke to the whole group now. “Let’s use this week to observe what stirs things up between our kids. Don’t let the discord go to waste. Write down the incidents or conversations that distress you. At our next meeting we’ll share our findings and take it from there.”

• • •

DRIVING HOME FROM the session I found myself thinking about my own sons, now grown. Still vivid in my mind is the conversation between them after last week’s Thanksgiving dinner.

Suddenly I’m standing in my dining room again, clearing the table, listening to the two of them as they start the cleanup in the kitchen.

At first they joke about dividing up the chores, each claiming a different speciality and trading off the “yecch” jobs. Then the talk grows serious as they compare their colleges and their majors—one in science, the other, art. All at once a heated debate erupts about who is more important to society, the artist or the scientist. “Look at Pasteur.” “Yeah, but

look at Picasso.” They go on and on, each trying to convince the other. Finally, worn down, they concede that *both* have value.

After a moment’s lull the conversation turns back into the past. An old anger is raked up and they argue again about who did what to whom and why, each explaining himself anew from his grown-up position. After a while the mood changes again. Warm funny memories are trotted out, and both boys collapse into laughter.

It’s almost as if two forces are at work: one pushing them apart as they use the differences between them to define their unique, separate selves; the other pulling them together so they can come to know their unique brotherhood.

As I half-listen from the next room, I am surprised at how relaxed I am. I realize how little emotional investment I have in the moment-by-moment “temperature” of their relationship. I know that the differences in interests and temperament that kept them from being close in childhood are still there. But I also know that over the years I had helped them build the bridges to span the separate islands of their identities. If they ever need to reach each other, they have many ways of getting there.